

ROSCOE'S GRAVE

A genealogy mystery

Who is really buried here?

THE STORY CONTINUES

Before the chisel

Before the opening brief

Ada Reeve wanted her mother's name cut neatly, deeply enough to last. After the funeral there had been so many questions with small answers: which papers to keep together, which address to give, what wording to send the mason. She had been grateful for a task that seemed to have an end.

At Holt & Son, the order lay ready. Edith beside Roscoe. A family's ordinary completion. Then the surname in the burial index stopped the work.

"Cross," Ada said. "That isn't my father's name."

The mason did not answer immediately. He had a job waiting and a bereaved customer in front of him. Neither made the discrepancy easier to explain.

"We could leave the existing inscription as it stands and add your mother."

"And the other name?"

He turned the order a little, as though an adjustment of paper might create a simpler question. "The office may have copied it wrongly."

At the records desk, Lydia Ames would not agree that it was an error before she had traced it. Ada found that irritating. She had come to finish something for Edith, not open another set of drawers.

"My mother knew where she meant to be buried," Ada said.

"Then we should follow the instructions she left."

"This is following them."

Lydia put the index beside the order. "It may be. Let us make sure we haven't mistaken an inscription for a burial entry."

Ada heard a correction when she needed condolences. She almost gathered up the papers. Instead she asked Lydia to show her the line again.

Her father's name on the stone was one of the fixed things in her life. The sea had taken him; the memorial had given the family somewhere to stand. She had not expected a clerical surname to disturb that arrangement years later.

But somebody had occupied the line in the book. If the book was wrong, Ada wanted it corrected. If it was right, she wanted to know whom her tidy addition would pass over.

She went back to the mason and asked him to wait. He looked at the unfinished order, then crossed out no names at all.

A name on a stone. A name in a book.

Briarport, Maine / 17 June 1937

Ada Reeve has returned to Briarport to settle her mother's affairs. All her life she has understood the weathered Hale stone to mark her father's grave. Now she wants her mother's name added beside his.

The mason will not begin. The cemetery's working index names someone else in that plot, and the neighboring space has its own history. Ada wants the discrepancy resolved before any stone is cut.

There are several possible explanations: an indexing mistake, a misplaced burial, or a family history nobody thought to tell her. The documents will let you distinguish them.

Your commission: Identify the person whose burial is documented beneath Roscoe's stone, establish the family relationship, explain the memorial, and recommend an accurate inscription.

Start: Read R01 and R02. Then use the archive catalog to choose a record that could answer your next question.

Case boundaries: The supplied register review covers all recorded interments and removals for this exact cemetery and plot through 16 June 1937. It does not cover every Cross family or establish facts about unrecorded physical remains. No exhumation, hidden clue, cipher or outside research is required.

Complete your final report on page 22 before opening the separate solution. All people, places, institutions and records are fictional. Evidence pages are readable typeset facsimiles or selected-field transcriptions, not authentic scans.

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Archive catalog

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READ FIRST

Read the people. Test the papers.

Print the Player PDF in full. This edition contains 26 pages, including its cover and interleaved story. Use US Letter, portrait, actual size / 100%; on A4, use Fit. Grayscale is sufficient. Single-sided lets you spread the records out; duplex uses the long edge. Keep the separate hints and sealed solution away from the player stack.

Follow the printed archive folios. Existing page references mean the numbers labeled ARCHIVE in the footers, which remain stable. New story leaves use S0-S3. They make the PDF positions different from the archive numbers. Use the bookmarks or clickable catalog to find a page on screen.

Begin with the opening scene and brief. Read R01-R02 and choose your next record through archive folio 3. Each later scene names the records to read first. In a nonlinear search, return to that scene after you have examined its records; scene order does not prove a connection.

Let the records carry the proof. The new scenes dramatize the people around these papers. They are fictional narrative, not additional archival exhibits. A character can be mistaken. Names, dates, parents, addresses, source references, and the supplied rules establish the case; sympathy does not.

Make your case. Use archive folios 20-22. Cite exhibit codes and exact fields, test alternatives, and leave unsupported matters open. Everyone investigates; no host, internet, cutting, or outside research is required. Use hints only when needed; open the solution after answering all final questions.

This case concerns bereavement and loss at sea, without graphic violence. A headstone, a memorial, and a recorded burial are different kinds of evidence.

The mason's work order

15 June 1937

Holt & Son, monumental masons / order H-88

Customer	Mrs Ada Reeve, daughter of Edith Hale
Requested work	Add Edith Hale, 1884-1937, beside the existing inscription
Site	Harbor Rest Cemetery, Briarport / G17
Existing inscription	ROSCOE HALE / 1881-1912 / THE SEA KEEPS ITS OWN
Work status	On hold pending cemetery record check

The index lists a different surname against G17. No alteration has been made. Before engraving, obtain the full burial entry and the original stone order. Confirm whether the proposed addition should refer to G17 or the adjoining space.

The inscription above is a faithful fictional transcription of the case stone. Decorative cover art is not a clue-bearing photograph.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

The cemetery working index

Updated through 16 June 1937

Harbor Rest Cemetery / names and plots / selected rows

Name in index	Plot	Date	Reference
Cross, M.	G17	9 Feb 1931	I-431
Hale, Edith	G18	12 Jun 1937	I-588
Hale, Roscoe	G17	1913	Stone book S-64
Plot review	G17: one recorded interment, I-431; no recorded removal		
Review period	Plot opened 1913 through 16 June 1937		
Register custodian	Lydia Ames		

This working index combines stone names with burial names. References prefixed I belong to the interment book. S references belong to the stone book. Consult the referenced records before amending a family entry.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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Three Cross entries

Deaths registered February 1931

Briarport and Bayhaven death indexes / search return

Name	Death	Age	District / entry
Miriam Cross	5 Feb 1931	72	Briarport / D-89
Mabel Cross	6 Feb 1931	85	Briarport / D-90
Marion Cross	5 Feb 1931	40	Bayhaven / D-204

Search requested for M. Cross associated with a February burial. These three entries are leads, not a proof that no other person with those initials existed. The original burial and undertaker references must decide which lead belongs to G17.

Do not combine entries merely because names or dates are similar. District identifiers are part of each reference.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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The interment book

9 February 1931

Harbor Rest Cemetery / volume IV / entry I-431

Name entered	M. Cross
Cemetery; plot	Harbor Rest, Briarport / G17
Burial date	9 February 1931
Undertaker	Bell & Tern / account U-572
Coffin seal	S44
Authority for plot use	Edith Hale / permission P-17
Disposition	One coffin received and interred
Stone present	Hale memorial, order S-64

Entry checked against the delivery docket. Grounds superintendent: Lydia Ames.
See plot plan for adjoining G18.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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Two funerals, two coffins

7-9 February 1931

Bell & Tern funeral accounts / U-572 and U-573

U-572

Deceased	Miriam Cross
Death register	Briarport D-89
Coffin seal	S44
Delivered	Harbor Rest / G17 / 9 February 1931
Cemetery receipt	I-431 / S44, signed L. Ames

U-573

Deceased	Mabel Cross
Death register	Briarport D-90
Coffin seal	S45
Delivered	North Field Cemetery / B6 / 9 February 1931
Cemetery receipt	NF-208 / S45, signed J. Dale

Accounts and cemetery receipts provide a documentary delivery chain. They do not substitute for a modern forensic identification.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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A widow's death registration

Registered 6 February 1931

Briarport town clerk / death entry D-89

Full name	Miriam Cross
Date of death	5 February 1931
Date of birth	29 July 1858
Age	72 years
Birthplace	Briarport, Maine
Father	Elias Dale
Mother	Hannah Boyd
Marital condition	Widow of William Cross
Last residence	11 Lantern Lane, Briarport
Informant	Arthur Cross, nephew of William Cross

Parent names here are reported by the informant. Compare them with records made during the person's lifetime.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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THE STORY CONTINUES

The person inside an initial

After R01-R06

Three similar names made Ada impatient with the index and with herself. She had arrived certain that a family grave must be a simple thing to identify. Now she was following references that looked capable of leading into three different lives.

Lydia brought the transfer accounts to the table. "We can compare the references before we decide what the surname means."

Ada glanced at the numbered seals. "You make it sound like a parcel."

"I know. These are the records of the arrangements. That is what they can tell us."

The answer annoyed Ada less than reassurance would have. Lydia had not promised that a paper chain was a physical examination. She was refusing to claim more certainty than the office possessed.

Ada copied the numbers. She checked the plot, the death registration, and the interment reference separately. A woman who had first appeared as an inconvenient initial began to have a full name and a history that extended beyond Ada's own family story.

At the mason's, Holt asked whether he should keep the proposed wording ready.

"Keep it," Ada said. "Don't cut it."

"Your mother is the part we know."

"She isn't the only person whose name would be on the stone."

He looked at her, then at the order. "No. She isn't."

Ada had wanted his impatience to be heartlessness. It would have given her a straightforward person to oppose. Instead he was a man accustomed to making a bereaved family's choice permanent, trying to get her to the point at which a choice could be made. His haste still mattered. It could still leave someone out.

Back at the desk, Lydia set the full entry where Ada could reach it without leaning across the other papers. She did not interpret the family relationship for her. The record supplied parents, a former surname, a spouse, an address. Those were routes into another set of records.

Ada kept the initial on her worksheet and wrote the full names underneath. Whatever had happened here, she would not solve it by making the least familiar person disappear first.

The original stone order

19 May 1913

Holt & Son / stone book / S-64

Ordered by	Edith Hale
Inscription	ROSCOE HALE / 1881-1912 / THE SEA KEEPS ITS OWN
Placement	Harbor Rest Cemetery / reserved plot G17
Burial associated with order	None; no remains delivered
Work supplied	Memorial stone and foundation only
Completed	28 June 1913

Mrs Hale directs that space G18 be reserved beside G17. The setting of this memorial is not an interment. Copy of the loss inquiry retained with the order.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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The harbor loss inquiry

Final entry: 4 December 1912

Briarport harbor office / fishing vessel Mercy / inquiry L-9

Vessel	Mercy, fishing smack
Last confirmed sighting	14 November 1912, east of Briarport
Crew missing	Roscoe Hale; Walter Ames
Wreckage identified	Hull board carrying vessel name; marked equipment
Identifiable human remains recovered	None
Inquiry status	Search concluded; both men presumed lost

Wreckage identification rests on the vessel marks. The master's account and shore departures establish the crew list. No witness to either man's death has been located. The office cannot certify a burial location.

This is an invented local inquiry. Its stated limits govern the case; it is not a claim about a historical maritime procedure.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

THE STORY CONTINUES

What the sea did not return

After R07-R08

Ada read the old stone order once, and then again more slowly. She had spent so much of her life seeing an inscription that she had given it powers no inscription possessed.

The shipping account was less consoling. Wreckage. A concluded search. No identifiable remains recovered. It told her what the search had found and what it had failed to bring home. It did not give her the last moment of her father's life.

"Did Mother think this was enough?" she asked.

Lydia stood beside the table. "I can't tell you what she thought."

Ada wanted her to try. A sympathetic invention would have been easy to accept that morning. She could feel the temptation and resented Lydia for leaving it visible.

"She put a name there," Ada said.

"Yes. That much we have."

Ada thought of the difference between having a place to grieve and having a body to bury. As a child she had not needed to hold that distinction in words. Now the records required it. They did not make her earlier visits meaningless. They made the purpose of the stone more deliberate than she had understood.

The phrase on it had sounded to her like an ending. The sea keeps its own. On the search paper there was no such finished sentence, only the limits of what people had been able to establish.

She closed her eyes, then opened them before Lydia could mistake it for permission to put the papers away.

"Keep going," Ada said.

The unknown surname remained. It no longer had to mean that her father's coffin had been exchanged or that the family had been cheated of a burial. Those were stories her alarm had offered before the records had supported them.

She was ashamed of how readily she had made the other occupant an intruder. Then she became angry again, this time at the years in which nobody had made the distinction plain to her. The archive did not tell her who knew what in every year. It left her to carry the anger without giving it an easy address.

A birth in the Hale family

Birth: 18 April 1881

St Anne's, Briarport / family register / B-102

Child	Roscoe Hale
Date of birth	18 April 1881
Baptism	15 May 1881
Father	Jonas Hale, cooper
Mother	Miriam Hale, formerly Dale
Residence	3 Dock Street, Briarport
Sponsors	Elias Dale and Hannah Dale

Entry made by Rev. Alfred Winn. Birth date and baptism date are entered in separate columns.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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A marriage on Dock Street

3 September 1879

St Anne's, Briarport / marriage register / M-44

Groom	Jonas Hale
Age; occupation	24; cooper
Bride	Miriam Dale
Age; birthplace	21; Briarport
Bride's parents	Elias Dale and Hannah Dale, formerly Boyd
Bride's birth date	29 July 1858
Intended residence	3 Dock Street, Briarport
Witnesses	Elias Dale and Sarah Winn

The birth date and parent pair are useful identity fields, not just the repeated given name.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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A second marriage

11 October 1888

St Anne's, Briarport / marriage register / M-91

Groom	William Cross, shipwright
Age; condition	34; bachelor
Bride	Miriam Hale, formerly Dale
Age; birth date	30; 29 July 1858
Condition	Widow of Jonas Hale, died 2 March 1886
Bride's parents	Elias Dale and Hannah Boyd
Residence after marriage	11 Lantern Lane, Briarport
Witnesses	Sarah Winn and Arthur Cross

The prior husband's death entry was produced when this marriage was recorded.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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The Lantern Lane household

Reference date: 1 June 1900

Selected census fields / Briarport / household 67

Name	Relation to head	Birth	Age
Cross, William	Head	Jan 1854	46
Cross, Miriam	Wife	Jul 1858	41
Hale, Roscoe	Step-son	Apr 1881	19

Address	11 Lantern Lane, Briarport
William's occupation	Shipwright
Roscoe's occupation	Fisherman
Years married: William and Miriam	11

Selected-field fictional transcription using the 1900 census reference date and relationship-to-head convention. The family register and marriages supply the parentage chain.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

Roscoe's marriage

6 July 1905

St Anne's, Briarport / marriages / M-180

Groom	Roscoe Hale
Age; occupation	24; fisherman
Groom's father	Jonas Hale, deceased
Groom's mother	Miriam Cross, formerly Hale, born Dale
Bride	Edith Winn
Age; birth date	21; 20 February 1884
Witnesses	Miriam Cross and Walter Ames
Home after marriage	4 Netmakers Row, Briarport

Both parties signed. Parents and former surnames entered before the witnesses.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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Instructions left in an envelope

7 January and 7 February 1931

Edith Hale papers / envelope attached to permission P-17

Miriam Cross to Edith Hale / 7 January 1931

Edith, when the time comes, I ask for G17. Jonas has his resting place in the old yard. There was no coffin when we put up the stone at Harbor Rest. Let mine be the first, if you are willing.

Keep the name that is already there. I have had years in which people could speak mine. He should not lose his place in the world because the sea did not send him home. Put my own name plainly in the burial book. I ask for no false entry.

Permission P-17 / signed Edith Hale / 7 February 1931

I authorize the burial requested above in G17. Retain the existing memorial. G18 remains reserved for my own burial. Deliver the coffin under Bell & Tern account U-572. The attached instructions are to remain with the plot papers.

The letter supports a stated wish. It does not establish what every family member knew or why later generations were not told.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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The adjoining plot and family record

12-16 June 1937

Harbor Rest / I-588; St Anne's family extract; plot plan

Interment I-588	Edith Hale, widow of Roscoe Hale
Date of death; burial	9 June 1937; 12 June 1937
Plot	Harbor Rest / G18
Next of kin	Ada Reeve, daughter
Family entry B-251	Ada Hale, born 2 May 1907
B-251 parents	Roscoe Hale and Edith Hale, formerly Winn
Later name reference	Ada Hale married Philip Reeve, 8 October 1928 / M-311

Plot plan G: G17 and G18 are adjoining single-burial spaces, with separate entries. The Hale memorial stands within G17. I-588 is entered only against G18. No transfer from G17 is recorded.

The record review ends on 16 June 1937. Report what the documents support at that date.

Research note / What does this establish? What should I check next?

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THE STORY CONTINUES

A request in a woman's own words

After R09-R15

The letter sounded unlike the ledgers. Its writer wanted something and could say why. Ada had to remind herself that this, too, was a person's account, not an office speaking for everyone involved.

She set it beside the permission and reread the request about the name in the burial book. The wish to keep Roscoe's name on the stone had not been a wish to falsify the record below it. Yet the two ways of remembering had become so unequal that Ada had grown up seeing one and missing the other.

"It was loving," she said.

Then, before Lydia could agree, "It was unfair."

Lydia let both sentences remain.

Ada studied the marriages and household. She could follow a change of surname without assuming a change of person. She could test the relationships through more than one field. None of that told her whether the woman who made this request had imagined how completely her own name would disappear from Ada's knowledge.

Edith's permission was there too. Ada wanted to question her mother about it. She wanted the ordinary irritation of an answer she could argue with. Instead she had an instruction, a signature, and a neighboring plot.

At Holt & Son, the mason suggested enough space for a separate tablet. He waited this time, leaving the wording blank.

"I haven't finished the family line," Ada told him.

"Bring it when you have."

It was the first answer of his that did not push her toward completion. She thanked him, and meant it.

Back at the archive desk, she arranged the papers by the links she needed to prove. The right inscription depended on identifying the occupant, explaining the connection, and distinguishing the two plots. It did not require her to settle whether her mother had been wise, whether grief had made a fair request, or whether she ought to feel injured by a silence no longer available for explanation.

Lydia handed her another sheet. Ada wrote the family line carefully. Before giving anyone a permanent name in stone, she would give the records a full hearing.

Follow the burial, not the initials.

Record the exact reference at every handoff. Keep alternate explanations until a field excludes them.

Stone and plot references / what each record represents

Interment to undertaker to death entry / names, seals and dates

Alternative Cross entries / evidence for exclusion

What the burial records establish / what they cannot establish

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Reconstruct the family behind the stone.

Track each surname change and label the relationship supported by its record.

The buried person / birth identity and parents

Marriages, spouses and changes of surname

Roscoe, Edith and Ada / relationship chain with exhibits

The original memorial and later burial / sequence and stated wishes

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What should the stone say?

Summarize here; put supporting details on your working sheets.

1. Who is documented as buried in G17? Give the full name and the delivery-reference chain.

2. How is that person related to Roscoe, Edith and Ada? Cite the surname and parentage links.

3. Why does Roscoe's name stand over this plot, and why was it retained after the burial?

4. Why do the other Cross entries and Edith's burial not belong to G17?

5. Propose accurate wording for a supplementary inscription. State what remains unknown about Roscoe.

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